MODULE 9

ASSIGNMENT: Run a real pricing test — and bank your first €500

A joint initiative by

CHECK-IN

Did you get your first paying customer?

1. The Sale — How much did they pay? How did you close it?
2. The Objections — What concerns did they raise?
3. The Request — What did they ask for immediately?

If no sale yet: what's blocking it? What would make them say yes?

RECAP: Where We Are

1. You contacted your first 10 potential customers — live, in class
2. You (hopefully!) banked your first outside euro
3. GPK verdicts confirmed — killed teams sell their concierge offer

Today: pricing, conversion, and taking money without breaking German law

Compliments are free. That's the problem.

Users tell you you're right. Revenue tells you you're real.

You have a prototype, feedback, maybe a first euro. This week we build the machine that turns users into customers.

Four ideas today:

- 1 — Price is a hypothesis (test it like one)
- 2 — Sell the pilot (your first offer is not a subscription)
- 3 — Conversion mechanics (make paying trivial)
- 4 — When money arrives: the Germany edition (GbR, §19, IP)

Today

Check-in & recap — who got paid? (15')

IDEA 1 · Price is a hypothesis (15')

IDEA 2 · Sell the pilot (10')

IDEA 3 · Make paying trivial (10')

IDEA 4 · When money arrives — the Germany edition (15')

Case · Superhuman: the $30/month decision (30')

Workshop · Revenue Sprint (90')

Wrap-up · this week's bar: €500 pass / €1,000 stretch (10')

IDEA 1: Price is a hypothesis

You don't find the right price — you test it: Van Westendorp on 10 real users, then one real ask at one committed price.

Stated interest lies. Paid invoices don't.

Price is a hypothesis

You don't find the right price. You test your way to it.

Cost-plus is for factories. Value-based is for you: price the outcome, not your effort.

A pricing failure is a diagnosis, not a defeat — it means wrong value story or wrong segment.

This week's experiment: one price · ten real prospects · pass/fail written down BEFORE you ask.

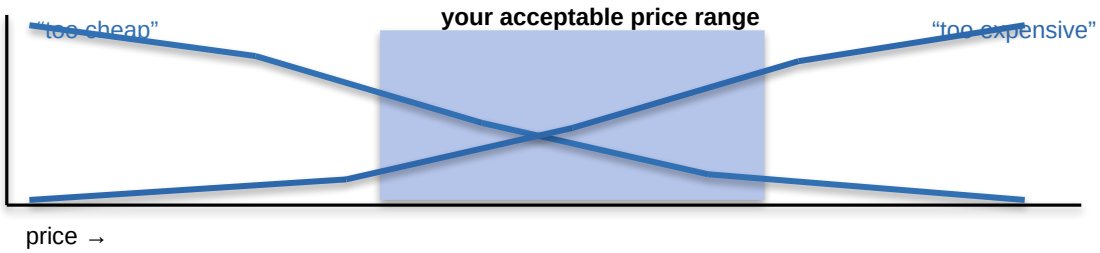
Van Westendorp: four questions that map willingness to pay

Ask your hair-on-fire segment (10+ people, this week):

- At what price would this be so expensive you'd never buy it? → Too expensive
- At what price would it be expensive, but still worth considering? → Expensive
- At what price would it be a bargain? → Cheap
- At what price would it be so cheap you'd doubt the quality? → Too cheap

Plot the four curves — the crossings frame your acceptable price range and a reference price point.

(Van Westendorp 1976 — a heuristic, not a law. Next slide.)



Read the curves — then distrust them (a little)

The range is a starting hypothesis, not an answer.

People overstate hypothetical willingness to pay — stated ≠ paid (Ding, Grewal & Liechty 2005).

So: use the curves to pick your test price, then validate with a REAL ask.

The only WTP data that fully counts: someone paid. Everything else is a smoke signal.

Anchor high. Keep it simple.

Anchoring: the first number frames everything after it. A €1 anchor puts you in hobby territory forever.

Superhuman priced a FREE category (email) at $30/month — the price itself was the positioning. (Today's case.)

Structure: three tiers max with one clearly recommended — or one plan and zero decision friction.

Charge more: raise the price until someone flinches. It takes longer than you think.

IDEA 2: Sell the pilot

Your first offer is a €300–500 paid pilot: fixed scope, agreed success criteria, converts to a subscription.

It filters the serious from the polite — and killed teams can sell it with zero product.

Sell the pilot

Your first offer is not a subscription. It's a paid pilot.

Structure: fixed scope · 2–4 weeks · €300–500 · success criteria agreed upfront · converts into a subscription.

The pilot price is a seriousness filter: whoever won't pay €300 once was never paying €30/month.

Killed your idea in Module 7? This is your concierge play — sell the service version of the solution. No product required.

Objections are data

'Too expensive' almost never means the number. It means the value story didn't land — or you're talking to the wrong segment.

The playbook:

- 1. 'Too expensive compared to what?' — find the reference point
- 2. 'What would make this a no-brainer?' — they design your offer
- 3. Shrink the scope before you shrink the price

Log every objection verbatim in the Toolkit. The same objection three times = your next product decision.

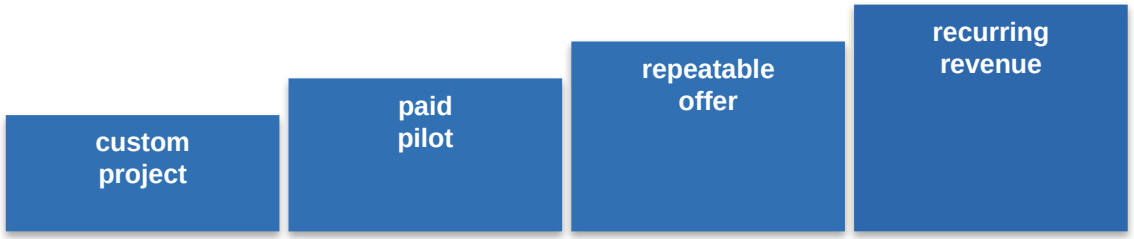
The consulting trap

€2,000 of custom work feels like winning. It's a job, not a company.

Revenue quality ladder: custom project < paid pilot < repeatable offer < recurring subscription

The leaderboard rewards repeatable revenue: same offer · more than one customer · no custom scope.

Rule of thumb: if the second sale needs a new proposal, you sold a project, not a product.



IDEA 3: Make paying trivial

Map the last mile from 'yes' to 'paid'. Build the ask into the product.

Payment link goes out while you're still on the call; follow-up inside 48 hours.

From activated user to paying customer

Map the last mile: activated → sees value → asked to pay → pays. Find where they fall off.

Most teams never ASK. The ask is a feature — build it this week.

Friction audit: count the clicks from 'yes' to 'paid'. Every extra step loses customers.



Make paying trivial

Stripe Payment Link or PayPal: a working checkout in 10 minutes — you'll wire it in today's workshop.

Selling B2B? Offer invoice + bank transfer. The German Mittelstand pays invoices, not checkout forms.

Send the payment link WHILE you're still on the call. Momentum closes; 'I'll send it later' doesn't.

The follow-up engine

The 48-hour rule: every open conversation gets a follow-up within two days. No exceptions.

Three touches, then stop: value-add → proof/story → clean break-up message.

Track everything in the Toolkit: sent / replied / objection / paid. Your pipeline is your homework evidence.

IDEA 4: When money arrives

You're a GbR with personal liability — whether you know it or not. §19 UStG keeps VAT away below €25k/€100k.

Ten minutes of plumbing, then back to selling. (Education, not legal advice.)

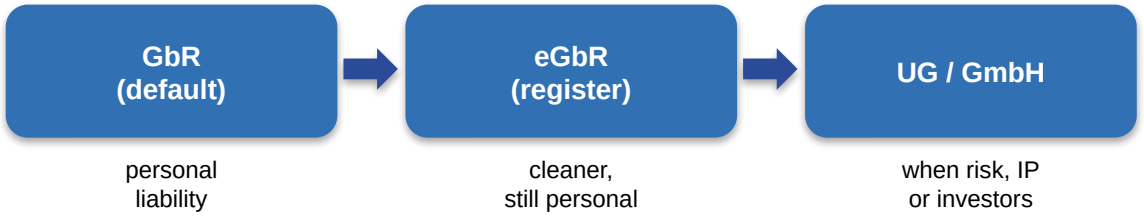
When money arrives: the Germany edition

Take money as a team with no setup and you are a GbR by default — with joint PERSONAL liability.

Since 2024 (MoPeG) the GbR can register as eGbR — cleaner, but liability stays personal.

Fine for first pilots and small amounts. Not fine once real money or real risk shows up.

This is education, not legal advice — book the free startup legal office hours BEFORE it matters.



Small revenue, small bureaucracy: §19 UStG

Kleinunternehmerregelung (since 2025): ≤ €25,000 revenue last year AND ≤ €100,000 this year → no VAT on your invoices.

Cross €100,000 mid-year and regular VAT applies immediately, from that transaction on. A hard cap, not a forecast.

Every invoice still needs: both names & addresses · date · invoice number · description · amount · the §19 no-VAT note.

Ten minutes of setup. Then go back to selling.

Payment rails & the IP question

Stripe/PayPal business accounts run KYC: expect ID checks and business details as soon as money flows.

A shared team account beats 'send it to Max's private PayPal' — clean books from euro one.

Your code, your thesis, your IP: as a student it is usually YOURS — but verify before you sell what you built in a lab. Ask TUM ForTe / Venture Labs.

UG (from €1) or GmbH? Not yet — wait for liability, IP pooling, or investors to demand it. Module 12 picks this up.

What the evidence says

Founders trained to state and TEST hypotheses earn more revenue and pivot more decisively — randomized controlled trial evidence (Camuffo, Cordova, Gambardella & Spina 2020, Management Science).

Pricing is exactly such a hypothesis: commit a threshold, run the ask, read the result.

Label your tools honestly:

- Van Westendorp = practitioner heuristic (1976)
- Stated willingness to pay inflates — validate with real transactions (Ding et al. 2005)
- Paid = proof. The hierarchy of evidence ends at recurring revenue.

The Revenue Ladder — printed once, valid everywhere

M08 first outside-€ (pass) · 3 paying users (stretch)

M09 €500 cumulative (pass) · €1,000 (stretch)

M10 €1,000 (pass) · €3,000 (stretch)

M11 €2,000 (pass) · €5,000 (stretch)

Demo Day €1,000 verified minimum · the €10,000 club

Rules: outside your social graph · dashboard/invoice-verified · repeatable beats consulting · paid twice beats paid once.



END RECAP — today in one breath

1 · Price is a hypothesis — committed threshold, ten real asks

2 · The paid pilot filters the serious from the polite

3 · The ask is a feature — the payment link goes out during the call

4 · GbR + §19: ten minutes of plumbing, then back to selling

Pass €500 · stretch €1,000 — see you on the leaderboard.

Workshop: Revenue Sprint (90 min)

Agenda lives in M09_Workshop_Revenue-Sprint.md — one source of truth, no deck copies.

Must produce today: your #1 improvement started + a committed 2-week revenue target — announced publicly.

Plus: payment link live and your pilot offer written down.

Kill criteria: two more weeks of 'improvements' with zero new revenue means you're polishing, not selling.

Bridge to Module 10: the 3 R's

RETENTION — do customers come back and use it again?

REFERRAL — do customers tell others without being asked?

REVENUE — are customers willing to pay (more) for it?

Homework: ship 3 improvements, push to €500 — Module 10 measures the 3 R's properly.

This week — or it didn't happen

MUST PRODUCE: a live pricing test (10 real asks at a real price) + working payment link.

PASS BAR: €500 cumulative. STRETCH: €1,000.

KILL CRITERIA: 10 asks and nobody pays even a pilot price → wrong story or wrong segment. Bring the objection log, we fix it in check-in.

Homework: M09_Homework.md — it feeds Module 10's PMF measurement directly.

Thank You!

A joint initiative by